



Sources of accommodation: The influence of nature verses social elicitors of awe

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INTRODUCTION

Awe is a unique positive emotion comprised of two crucial factors: it being a feeling in response to something vast and its ability to inspire a need for accommodation or the need to change one’s frame of mind (Keltner & Haidt, 2003). Prior research has found empirical evidence for nature stimuli (e.g. vast sweeping landscapes) (Piff, et al., Rudd, et al., 2012; Shiota et al., 2006; 2007; Valesolo, et al., 2014), and social stimuli (e.g. the example of someone selflessly sacrificing for others) (Shiota et al., 2006; Yaden et al., 2016) to elicit perceived vastness and result in feelings of awe. However, the effect of social stimuli to elicit a need for accommodation has not been specifically addressed.

PURPOSE

To further investigate the effect of social elicitors on a need for accommodation.

HYPOTHESIS

Social elicitors of awe will positively relate to a need for accommodation.

METHODS

Participants

Participants included 250 undergraduate students; 67.2% females, 81.2% White; mean age= 20.74 years (SD=2.599).

Procedure

Participants were randomly assigned to one of six experimental conditions (See Figure 1).

Measures

- *Awe Experience Scale (AWE-S)*: $\alpha=.90$ (Yaden, et al., 2018).
- *Appraisals of Awe Related Experiences (APRS)*: $\alpha=.72$ (Shiota et al., 2007).
- *Moral Elevation*: $\alpha=.95$ (Aquino & McFerran, 2011)

RESULTS

A significant main effect was found. As hypothesized, both nature and social elicitors resulted in significantly higher need for accommodation scores compared to the humor conditions (See Table 2 and Fig. 1).

Table 1 Study Condition and Sample Size.

Group Name	Number of Participants	Variable Grouping
Irena Sendler Audio	52	Social Elicitors
Irena Sendler Video	43	
Liam and Emma Audio	37	
Awe Nature Video	38	Nature Elicitor
Humor Audio	44	Controls
Humor Video	36	

Table 2 Need for Accommodation Tests.

Between Subject ANOVA Test			
Need for Accommodation	$F(2, 247) = 19.062$	$\eta^2 = .134$	$p < .001$
Post Hoc Comparisons (Scheffe Correction)			
Controls to Nature Elicitor	$t(116) = -4.04$	$d = -0.813$	$p < .001$
Controls to Social Elicitors	$t(210) = -5.984$	$d = -0.851$	$p < .001$
Nature Elicitor to Social Elicitors	$t(168) = -0.282$	$d = -0.051$	$p = .961$

Note: a, b, and c indicate heterogeneous groups from post hoc comparisons using Scheffe correction. All differences are at the $p < .001$ level.

Figure 1. Need for Accommodation Scores by Test Condition

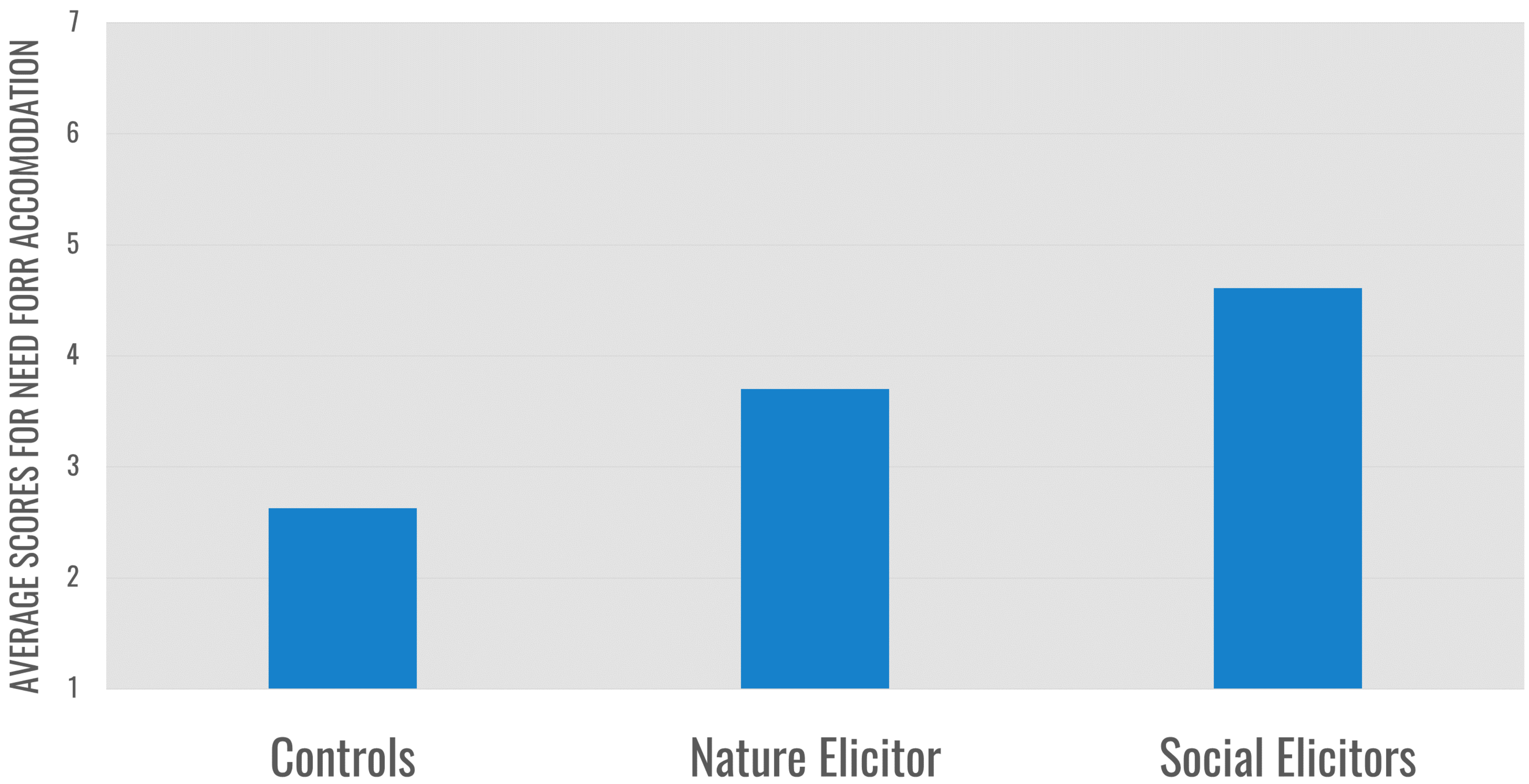
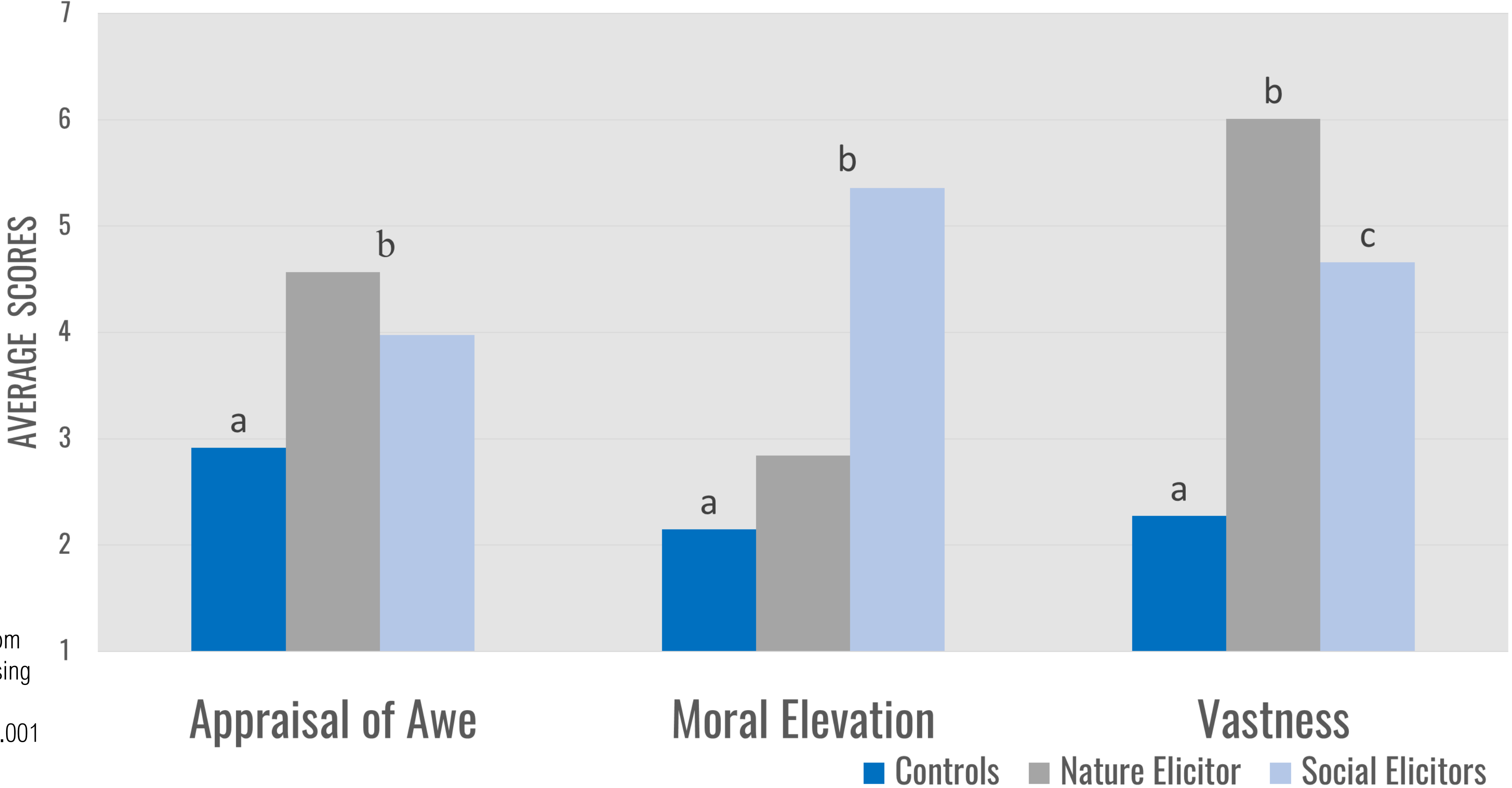


Figure 2. Comparisons of Key Outcomes



CONCLUSIONS

Interacting with nature can leave us awestruck by the vastness of the stimuli and encourages a need for accommodation; however, it may be that participants are left with little direction, thereafter. In contrast, social elicitors may inspire an increased motivation to adopt additional morals or perhaps result in greater introspection. A need for accommodation may pave a welcome path to personal introspection and explain an increase of prosocial behavior seen in prior studies.



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